with painting and carving.' About the building of Fatehpur Sikri, Jahangir would write that 'in the course of fourteen or fifteen years that hill, full of wild beasts, became a city containing all kinds of gardens and buildings and lofty, elegant edifices and pleasant places, attractive to the heart'. One of the first buildings to have been completed was the Jami mosque, which incorporated features from Hindu temples, making it unique in the Islamic world. Like the triplication of the domes of a Hindu temple, the Jami mosque has a triad of domes and is located on a high platform, with a lofty and wide view of the city below. When Shaikh Salim Chishti died, in 1571, his dargah was built in the courtyard of the Jami mosque, adding another layer of mystical sacrality to the space. An enormous Buland Darwaza, a victory gateway built to commemorate the Gujarat victories, has a surprising inscription in Naskh calligraphy that purports to quote Jesus: 'The World is a Bridge, pass over it, but build no houses upon it. He who hopes for a day, may hope for eternity; but the World endures but an hour. Spend it in prayer, for the rest is unseen.' Though not part of any canonical Christian text, this quote is from a body of Jesus's sayings from Islamic lore, possibly from early oral Christian traditions. It is a silent and enigmatic witness to some of the most audacious experiments in cultural and philosophical syncretism that were to ever take place in India.

As the various buildings of Fatehpur Sikri came up, they reflected a joyous mix of Timurid, Rajasthani, and Gujarati sultanate architecture. The haramsara, or ladies' quarters, the so-called Birbal's palace, the so-called Jodh Bai's palace, and then later the diwane-aam and innumerable more buildings combined the arch and dome of Islamicate architecture with delicate lattice-work jaalis and chattris (umbrellas) as well as Gujarati trabeation—beams. Akbar himself took a keen interest in the works, with Monserrate noting that '[Akbar] is so devoted to building that he sometimes quarries stone himself, along with the other workmen.' The fearsome flirted with the decorative as when one of the great gates of the city was festooned with 'chains, manacles, handcuffs and other irons' to deter all possible crooks and brigands. The Jesuits agreed that this was to 'inspire terror than for actual use' because the chief executioner too was wont to present himself at court positively brimming with 'leather thongs, whips, bow-strings fitted with sharp spikes of copper, a smooth block of wood used for pounding the criminals' sides or crushing to pieces his skull and scourges in